

A prison crisis

India's prisons are in crisis. They **resemble overcrowded** warehouses for **the forgotten**. The India Justice Report 2025 shows the **scale** of the problem. As of 2022, 5.73 lakh **inmates** were **lodged in** facilities built for 4.36 lakh. That's a 131 per cent **occupancy rate**. By 2030, the prison population could reach 6.8 lakh — far beyond the **projected** capacity of 5.15 lakh. The crisis goes deeper than space. It's a human rights emergency. There are just 25 **psychologists** for the entire prison population. **Mental illness** among inmates **has** more than doubled since 2012. Most of those suffering are **undertrials** — people not yet **convicted**. They wait years for justice because of court delays. The medical crisis is equally **grim**. There is a 43 per cent vacancy in medical officer posts across prisons. Delhi has only one doctor per 206 inmates. Without proper care, prisoners suffer in silence — both mentally and physically.

This neglect is not new. The Supreme Court has **often called for** long-term prison planning. But state action remains slow and **indifferent**. Staff shortages are severe. Correctional vacancies reach 60 per cent in some regions. Delhi's **jails**, for example, **have** operated at over 250 per cent capacity. **Marginalised communities** — Dalits, tribals and Muslims — **are** overrepresented **behind bars**. This **reflects deep-rooted inequities** in the justice system.



Addressing this crisis needs political **will**. Fast-track courts and alternative dispute resolution can reduce undertrial numbers. Infrastructure investment must match rising inmate numbers. More doctors, psychologists and staff are urgently needed. **Legal aid** access must improve for the poor. Prisons should not be sites of **prolonged** punishment. They must become centres of reform. **Treating** inmates with dignity and care **reflects** the strength of our democracy. It is not a favour — it is a constitutional duty.

[Practice Exercise]

- Red/blue coloring of words in the sentence indicates subject verb relationship; where 'red' denotes 'subject' and 'blue' denotes 'verb'.

Vocabulary

1. **Resemble** (verb) – look like, be similar to, mirror, echo, parallel जैसा दिखना
2. **Overcrowded** (adjective) – jam-packed, congested, crammed, packed, bursting अत्यधिक भीड़भाड़ वाला
3. **The forgotten** (noun) – neglected people, ignored, overlooked, abandoned, marginalized उपेक्षित लोग
4. **Scale** (noun) – extent, magnitude, range, degree, size पैमाना
5. **Inmate** (noun) – prisoner, convict, detainee, offender, jailbird कैदी
6. **Lodge** (in) (verb) – house, accommodate, confine, shelter, detain ठहराना / बंद करना
7. **Occupancy rate** (noun) – the number of available rooms that are occupied over a period of time.
8. **Projected** (adjective) – estimated, expected, forecasted, predicted, anticipated अनुमानित
9. **Psychologist** (noun) – mental health expert, therapist, counselor, analyst, shrink मनोवैज्ञानिक
10. **Undertrial** (noun) – a person who is being held in custody awaiting trial for a crime विचाराधीन कैदी
11. **Convict** (verb) – find guilty, sentence, condemn, imprison, penalize दोषी ठहराना
12. **Grim** (adjective) – bleak, harsh, severe, gloomy, depressing गंभीर / भयानक
13. **Often** (adverb) – frequently, regularly, repeatedly, commonly, usually अक्सर
14. **Call for** (phrasal verb) – demand, request, require, urge, advocate मांग करना
15. **Indifferent** (adjective) – unconcerned, apathetic, unresponsive, detached, negligent उदासीन
16. **Marginalised** (adjective) – sidelined, excluded, disadvantaged, oppressed, ignored हाशिए पर डाले गए
17. **Behind bars** (phrase) – imprisoned, in jail, incarcerated, detained, locked up जेल में
18. **Reflect** (verb) – show, indicate, reveal, demonstrate, mirror प्रतिबिंबित करना
19. **Deep-rooted** (adjective) – entrenched, ingrained, established, persistent, chronic गहरी जड़ें जमा हुआ
20. **Inequity** (noun) – injustice, unfairness, discrimination, disparity, bias अन्याय / असमानता
21. **Address** (verb) – deal with, tackle, handle, respond to, resolve निपटना
22. **Will** (noun) – determination, intent, resolve, purpose, desire इच्छाशक्ति

23. **Legal aid** (noun) – legal assistance, legal support, representation, court help, public defense विधिक सहायता

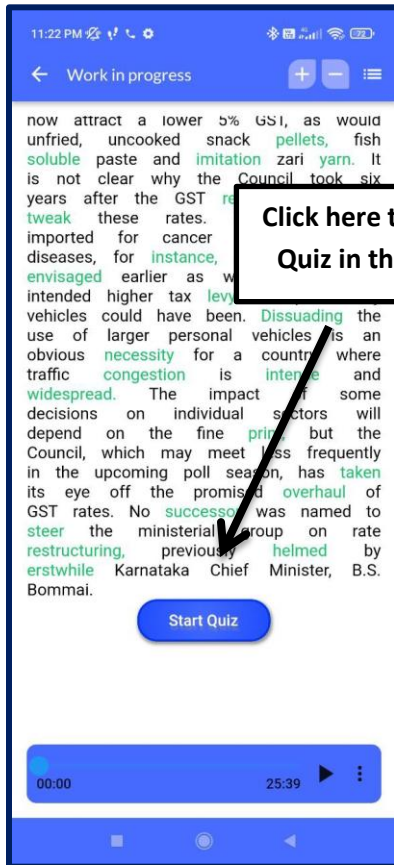
24. **Prolonged** (adjective) – extended, lengthy, drawn-out, protracted, sustained लम्बा खिंचा हुआ

@mocks_wallah

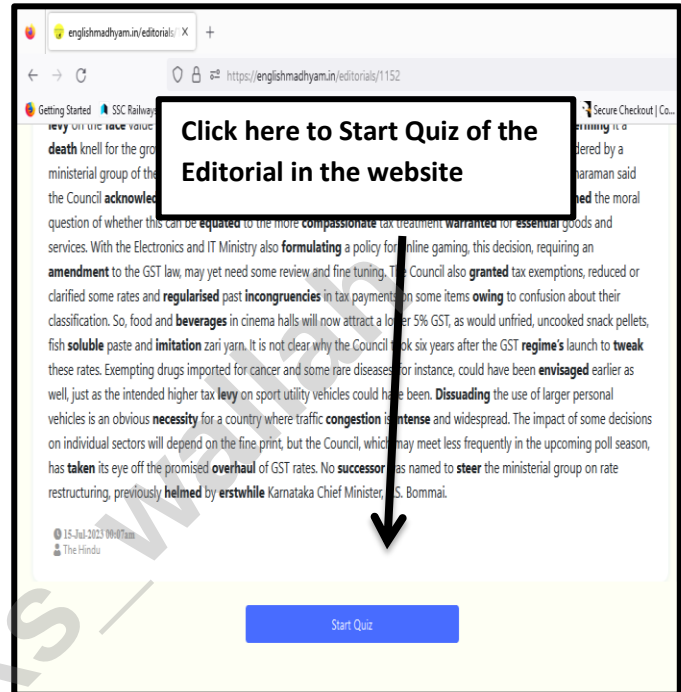
Summary of the Editorial

1. **India's prisons are severely overcrowded**, with 5.73 lakh inmates in 2022 against a capacity of 4.36 lakh — a 131% occupancy rate.
2. By **2030**, the prison population is projected to rise to **6.8 lakh**, far exceeding the future capacity of 5.15 lakh.
3. The issue is more than spatial — it is a **human rights emergency** rooted in systemic neglect.
4. There are only **25 psychologists** available for the entire prison population, amid a surge in **mental illness**, especially among undertrials.
5. **Undertrials**, or those awaiting trial, form a major portion of inmates, often enduring long waits due to **judicial delays**.
6. **Healthcare infrastructure** is deeply inadequate — there's a **43% vacancy** in medical officer posts, with Delhi having just **one doctor per 206 inmates**.
7. Inmates suffer both **physically and mentally**, often without proper care or attention.
8. The crisis is **long-standing**, with repeated **Supreme Court warnings** on the need for better prison planning.
9. **Staff shortages** remain acute — correctional posts have a **60% vacancy** in some regions.
10. Delhi jails, notably, operate at **over 250% capacity**, reflecting extreme pressure on the system.
11. **Marginalised communities** — Dalits, tribals, and Muslims — are **disproportionately incarcerated**, pointing to **systemic injustices**.
12. **Political will** is essential to address the crisis meaningfully and sustainably.
13. Solutions include **fast-track courts** and **alternative dispute resolution mechanisms** to reduce the number of undertrials.
14. There is an urgent need to **invest in prison infrastructure** and **recruit more doctors, psychologists, and staff**.
15. Prisons must transform into **centres of reform and dignity**, not sites of prolonged punishment — upholding this is a **constitutional obligation**, not an act of charity.

Practice Exercise: SSC Pattern Based



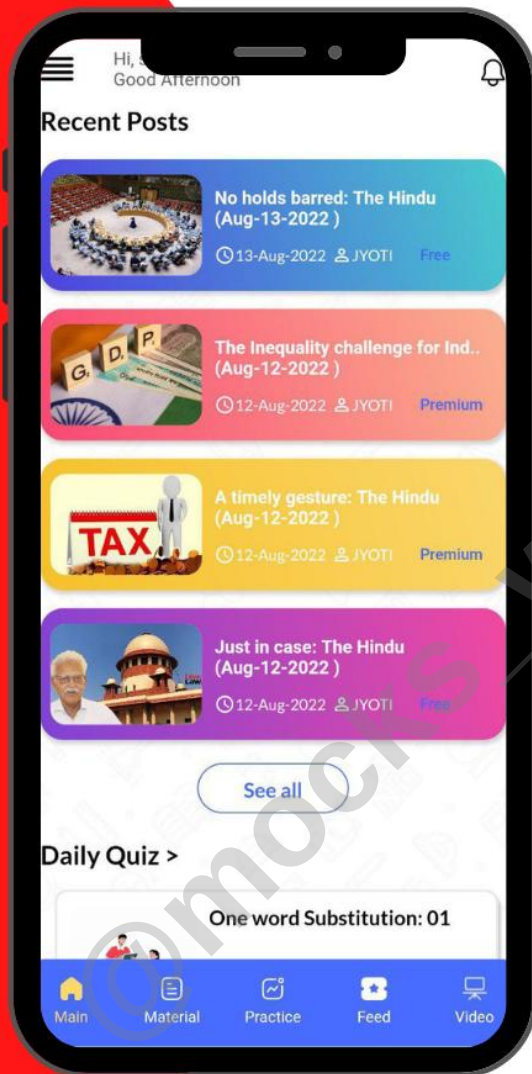
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